especially in his first five-year term. He also spoke of the importance of India's neighbourhood, the need for building regional institutions and deepening economic ties and building connectivity between the various countries of South Asia. He was unable during his ten years in power to implement many of his policies in the region even though he put forth a number of suggestions.

Manmohan Singh's decade-long stint as prime minister was not distinguished by new ideas or successful foreign policy initiatives. One major step during that period was the conclusion of the US–India civil nuclear deal, negotiations over which were started in the Vajpayee years and concluded in 2005. The deal separated India's civil and military nuclear programmes, allowed purchase of nuclear material under IAEA safeguards by India for civilian purposes and opened the possibility of India's membership of the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) without signing the Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT). The Manmohan Singh government had to overcome considerable opposition from within the ranks of its left-leaning coalition to secure parliamentary approval of this major agreement.

A MODI ERA?

The 2014 election brought the BJP to office after ten years in opposition, with Narendra Modi as prime minister. Unlike Vajpayee, who owed his position solely to the party, Modi's personal popularity was a major factor in his party's electoral success. This gave him considerable leeway in defining his own foreign policy. The Modi doctrine, though still evolving, appears to have elements of both continuity and change with his predecessors. Despite the desire to be different from the Congress and Nehru, Modi's foreign policy still has much in common with Nehru's, though he envisions a more powerful India than its first prime minister.

Modi, like Nehru and several other prime ministers, has so far ensured that foreign and security policy is formulated in the Prime Minister's Office